

PreACT 8/9 Printable Practice Exam 07

Reading • Exam 02

25 questions • 30 minutes

PART A - QUESTIONS

Passage 1

The Long Way on Paper

Tessa's map of the Harbor Walk fit perfectly on one sheet of paper. She had measured every turn, drawn the shoreline in a smooth blue curve, and marked the finish with a tiny flag. On Friday evening, two hundred copies were supposed to roll from her father's printing press. On Saturday morning, families would follow the map during the neighborhood scavenger walk.

At the planning meeting, Mr. Okafor studied Tessa's draft through square glasses. He had delivered mail in the neighborhood for thirty years and knew its shortcuts better than anyone. His finger stopped at the old railway underpass.

"That tunnel collects water after a hard rain," he said.

Tessa glanced through the community-center window. The clouds had already emptied and were breaking apart. "The weather is clearing. Besides, the underpass is the shortest route."

Mr. Okafor folded the map but did not return it. "A line can be short on paper and still be a long problem on foot."

Tessa wanted to defend the tidy page. The alternate route climbed Market Hill, bent around the library, and would force her to redraw nearly everything. Instead, she tucked the map under her jacket and borrowed her brother's bicycle.

At the underpass, brown water covered the path from wall to wall. Tessa stopped where the pavement disappeared. A branch floated through the tunnel and caught against the railing. She imagined a parent pushing a stroller toward the water or a child racing ahead of the group. The blue line on her map suddenly looked less like a direction and more like a promise she had not checked.

Back at the print shop, her father had arranged blank paper beside the press. "Ready?" he asked.

Tessa spread out her damp map. "Not yet." She explained what she had found and pointed to the longer route. If she changed it, they might miss the evening pickup for the boxes of printed maps.

Her father switched off the press light. The shop, normally full of clicking and humming, held its breath. "The machine can wait," he said. "Can the walkers?"

Tessa erased the underpass route. At first, the new line seemed to crowd everything else. Then she noticed that Market Hill passed the fire station's painted doors and a courtyard where three enormous sycamore trees grew. She moved two scavenger clues to those places and added a bench symbol halfway up the hill. Mr. Okafor returned with hot sandwiches and tested the directions aloud while Tessa worked.

The printing finished late. On Saturday, Tessa stood near the hill, expecting complaints about the climb. Instead, children counted the painted stars on the fire-station doors, and several walkers rested beneath the sycamores. When Mr. Okafor reached the top, he held up the map.

"Not the shortest," he said.

Tessa watched a family compare the real courtyard with her small green symbols. "No," she replied, "but it gets people where I said it would."

R2-001

Why is Tessa initially reluctant to use the alternate route?

- A) She believes Mr. Okafor wants to cancel the entire event.
- B) She has never visited Market Hill or the library.
- C) It would require major changes to her tidy map and might delay printing.
- D) It would lead walkers through the flooded railway underpass.

R2-002

It can reasonably be inferred that Tessa's father switches off the press light because he wants to:

- A) give Tessa time to choose an accurate route instead of rushing to print.
- B) show that the press has broken and cannot be used that evening.
- C) persuade Tessa to keep the shorter route through the underpass.
- D) wait until Mr. Okafor agrees to pay for the printing.

R2-003

In the sentence "The shop, normally full of clicking and humming, held its breath," the phrase "held its breath" most nearly suggests that the shop became:

- A) dangerously hot.
- B) filled with unfamiliar noises.
- C) too crowded for Tessa to work.
- D) quiet, as if waiting for a decision.

R2-004

What is the main function of the scene at the flooded underpass?

- A) It explains why Mr. Okafor stopped delivering mail.
- B) It turns a warning into visible evidence that causes Tessa to reconsider her map.
- C) It shows that Tessa's bicycle cannot travel on wet pavement.
- D) It introduces the locations used for the scavenger clues on Market Hill.

R2-005

How does Tessa's understanding of a map change during the passage?

- A) She begins by seeing maps as historical records and ends by seeing them as decorations.
- B) She begins by distrusting printed maps and ends by refusing to use them.
- C) She begins by valuing neatness and shortness but comes to see directions as a responsibility to walkers.
- D) She begins by drawing for families but decides maps should be made only for mail carriers.

R2-006

Which choice best summarizes the passage?

- A) After checking a warned-about route, Tessa accepts a printing delay and redesigns her map to guide walkers safely along a more interesting path.
- B) Tessa cancels a neighborhood walk when her father refuses to print a map that includes Market Hill.
- C) Mr. Okafor secretly redraws Tessa's map and moves every scavenger clue without consulting her.
- D) Families ignore Tessa's map because they prefer the shortest route through a flooded tunnel.

Passage 2

Passage A: Let the Copy Do Some Work

In our transportation museum, visitors once viewed a nineteenth-century train brake from behind glass. Its iron handle and gears were easy to see but difficult to understand. Then our exhibit team built a full-size working reproduction. Now visitors can pull the handle and watch wooden wheels slow as the gears press a model brake shoe against them. The original remains protected nearby, while

the copy helps explain what the original did.

Reproductions are sometimes dismissed as second-rate objects. That judgment overlooks what a carefully made copy can offer. A copy may be handled, opened, tested, or even repaired in front of visitors. It can reveal motion and texture that a fragile original cannot safely provide. Reproductions can also replace missing parts in a demonstration, allowing people to study a complete process instead of a single surviving piece.

Copies must be labeled honestly. Visitors should know what is old, what is newly made, and which features are based on evidence rather than certainty. When those distinctions are clear, a reproduction does not compete with an original. It becomes a tool for asking better questions about the original.

Passage B: What the Original Still Knows

A wooden bowl in a local history collection may look ordinary until light reveals knife marks beneath its rim. A darkened patch may show where a thumb repeatedly rested. Such traces are not decoration. They are physical evidence of how one particular object was made and used.

This evidence is why original objects deserve careful attention. No reproduction, however accurate its measurements, can carry the exact history of wear, repair, and accident found in the object it copies. If visitors encounter only smooth stand-ins, they may miss the uncertainty that makes historical study interesting. A scratch might come from daily use, later damage, or the maker's tool. The original preserves the question even when it does not supply an easy answer.

That does not make reproductions useless. A model may show how separate pieces once fit together, and a touchable copy may give more people access to an object's shape. But the copy should guide attention back to the surviving evidence, not replace it. In a strong exhibit, the reproduction explains a possible function while the original reminds viewers that the past was physical, specific, and never perfectly neat.

R2-007

Which choice best states the central idea of Passage A?

- A) Museums should replace all fragile objects with working machines.
- B) Visitors learn best when historical objects are left entirely unexplained.
- C) Reproductions are valuable only when no original object survives.
- D) Clearly labeled reproductions can help visitors explore features that originals cannot safely demonstrate.

R2-008

Why does Passage A begin with the example of the train brake?

- A) To prove that working train brakes are safer when built from wood.
- B) To illustrate how a reproduction can make an original object's operation easier to understand.
- C) To show that visitors damaged the original brake by touching it.
- D) To argue that transportation museums should contain only machines.

R2-009

According to Passage B, why are marks of wear on an original object important?

- A) They may provide evidence about how that particular object was made and used.
- B) They prove that every scratch was created by the object's original maker.
- C) They make it possible to determine an object's exact age without other evidence.
- D) They show that the object should be repaired until its surface looks new.

R2-010

As used in Passage B, "stand-ins" most nearly refers to:

- A) museum employees who explain an exhibit.

- B) original objects that have uncertain histories.
- C) substitutes made to represent original objects.
- D) tools used to repair scratches and worn surfaces.

R2-011

The passages differ mainly in that Passage A emphasizes what reproductions allow visitors to do, while Passage B emphasizes:

- A) why museum visitors should avoid asking questions about objects.
- B) how copies can carry the exact wear of individual originals.
- C) why working mechanisms are more important than historical evidence.
- D) what unique physical evidence an original object preserves.

R2-012

Which statement would both authors most likely support?

- A) A reproduction should be presented without revealing that it is newly made.
- B) A reproduction can be useful when its role is clear and it directs attention to historical evidence.
- C) An original object should always be handled by visitors before they view a copy.
- D) A museum must choose between displaying originals and displaying reproductions.

Passage 3

Ideas Before Voices

In many group discussions, the first confident suggestion becomes the starting point for everything that follows. Later speakers may improve that idea, yet they may also stop considering other possibilities. Social scientist Lian Perez and her team wondered whether a short period of silent idea writing could change the range of proposals a group considered.

The researchers recruited twenty-four teams of eighth- and ninth-grade students from three schools. Each team received the same challenge: recommend one redesign for an unused school courtyard. Half the teams began with twelve minutes of open discussion. The other half spent the first four minutes writing ideas individually on unmarked cards, then discussed for eight minutes. Thus, both groups had twelve minutes to generate and discuss ideas. In the silent-first teams, a facilitator shuffled the cards and read them aloud without identifying their authors.

Researchers counted the number of distinct proposals each team considered. They also recorded how evenly speaking time was shared and asked three architects, who did not know which routine a team had used, to rate the final plans for usefulness and originality.

The open-discussion teams considered an average of 4.1 distinct proposals. The silent-first teams considered 6.7. Speaking time in the silent-first teams was also distributed more evenly, although it did not become perfectly equal. The architects' ratings of usefulness were similar for both groups, but they rated the silent-first teams' final plans slightly higher in originality.

Interviews after the activity helped explain the pattern. Several students said an idea sounded more worthy of discussion when it was read from an anonymous card than when it came from someone who rarely spoke. One student explained, "We argued with the suggestion instead of deciding first whether the person usually has good suggestions." Other students said the cards made the discussion feel crowded at the beginning because the team had more options to sort.

The study does not show that silent writing is best for every decision. Each team worked together only once, and redesigning a courtyard may encourage different behavior than solving a conflict or making an urgent choice. Facilitators also knew which routine each team used, though the outside architects did not. Still, the comparison suggests that changing the first few minutes can prevent an early voice from narrowing the entire discussion.

Perez does not argue for silent meetings. Instead, she describes the writing period as a wider doorway into conversation. Once more ideas have entered, students still need to question, combine, and

choose among them aloud.

R2-013

Which choice best states the main idea of the passage?

- A) Courtyard design is too complex for students to discuss in groups.
- B) Anonymous cards prevent groups from making final decisions.
- C) Writing ideas silently before discussion may broaden the ideas and participation included in a group's conversation.
- D) Architects and students usually agree about which designs are most useful.

R2-014

Which result did the researchers observe?

- A) Silent-first teams considered more distinct proposals on average than open-discussion teams.
- B) Open-discussion teams received much higher usefulness ratings from the architects.
- C) Speaking time became perfectly equal in every silent-first team.
- D) Open-discussion teams produced an average of 6.7 distinct proposals.

R2-015

What is the main purpose of including the student's comment about arguing with the suggestion instead of judging the person?

- A) To show that students could identify the authors of all the anonymous cards.
- B) To explain why the architects refused to rate the final plans.
- C) To prove that open discussion always leads to personal arguments.
- D) To illustrate how anonymity may shift attention from a speaker's reputation to the idea itself.

R2-016

Why did both routines provide twelve total minutes for generating and discussing ideas?

- A) To guarantee that every team would produce the same number of proposals.
- B) To make time equal across conditions so the opening routine was the main planned difference.
- C) To allow the architects to join each team for the final four minutes.
- D) To prevent facilitators from knowing which routine their teams used.

R2-017

Which combination of findings most strongly supports the claim that the silent-first routine broadened participation rather than merely increasing the number of ideas?

- A) The activity involved three schools, and every team redesigned a courtyard.
- B) The architects did not know which routine each team had used, and usefulness ratings were similar.
- C) Speaking time was more evenly distributed, and students said anonymous cards helped ideas from infrequent speakers receive consideration.
- D) Some students thought the opening felt crowded, and each team worked together only once.

R2-018

Which choice best describes the passage's overall structure?

- A) It introduces a concern about group discussions, describes a comparison study, reports results and limitations, and explains a possible application.
- B) It presents a courtyard design, lists objections to it, and then supplies a corrected blueprint.
- C) It tells the history of anonymous writing before arguing that spoken discussion should end.
- D) It compares three schools in order to rank their students' creativity.

Passage 4

A Seed's Twisting Tail

The seeds of some grasses carry two thin bristles called awns. When the air becomes dry, layers within each awn shrink by different amounts, causing the bristle to twist. In damp air, it loosens again. Repeated changes in humidity can make the seed shift across the ground even though the seed has no muscles.

Botanist Maren Cho wanted to learn how this motion works on different surfaces. Her team collected seeds from one grass species and divided them into two groups. The first group kept both awns. On the second group, the awns were carefully trimmed away without damaging the seed body. The trimmed seeds served as a comparison, allowing the team to separate awn-driven movement from shifts caused by air currents or handling.

The researchers prepared trays with three surfaces: smooth clay, cracked clay, and a loose layer of dry leaf pieces. They arranged equal numbers of intact and trimmed seeds on each surface, photographed their starting positions, and placed the trays in a chamber. For twenty cycles, the chamber alternated between dry and humid air. Cameras took one image each minute.

On smooth clay, intact seeds turned and traveled farther than trimmed seeds, but they often ended where they had started after reversing direction. Cracked clay produced a different result. An awn would catch on one side of a crack while the seed rotated, then hold its new position when the humidity changed. In this way, many intact seeds ratcheted forward and lodged partway into cracks. Trimmed seeds rarely did so.

The leaf layer produced mixed results. Some awns became tangled before the seeds moved far. In other cases, a leaf edge acted as an anchor, helping the twisting seed push beneath the loose material. The same structure that blocked motion in one position assisted it in another.

To test whether the movement required living cells, the team removed several awns from seeds that were no longer able to grow. The detached awns still twisted as humidity changed. This result supports a physical explanation: the arrangement of fibers in the dry tissue drives the motion, rather than an active response controlled by the living seed.

Cho cautioned that the chamber produced regular humidity cycles, while outdoor changes are less predictable. Wind, rain, soil animals, and steeper surfaces could strengthen or overwhelm the awns' effects. Even so, the experiment shows how a structure no thicker than a thread can use changes in the air to move a seed toward a possible shelter.

R2-019

Which choice best states the central idea of the passage?

- A) Grass seeds can move only when wind carries them across smooth surfaces.
- B) Leaf litter always prevents awned seeds from reaching soil.
- C) Living cells inside a seed actively command each awn to twist.
- D) Humidity-driven twisting of awns can reposition seeds, but the outcome depends on the surface and available anchors.

R2-020

Why did the researchers include seeds whose awns had been trimmed away?

- A) To determine whether trimmed seeds could grow into a different grass species.
- B) To distinguish movement caused by awns from movement caused by handling or air currents.
- C) To keep equal numbers of seeds from touching cracked clay.
- D) To test whether leaf pieces supplied nutrients to the seed body.

R2-021

As used in the description of movement on cracked clay, "ratcheted" most nearly means:

- A) dissolved after becoming wet.
- B) returned completely to the starting point.
- C) advanced in small steps while being held from fully slipping backward.

D) rose straight into the air without touching the surface.

R2-022

Which step occurred before the trays underwent twenty humidity cycles?

- A) The researchers photographed the seeds' starting positions on the three prepared surfaces.
- B) The researchers concluded that cracked clay prevented intact seeds from moving.
- C) The researchers exposed all trays to outdoor wind and rain.
- D) The researchers removed the leaf layer after the awns became tangled.

R2-023

What can reasonably be inferred from the detached awns continuing to twist?

- A) Awn movement occurs only while a seed can still grow.
- B) The chamber cameras caused the fibers to change shape.
- C) Living seed cells must send instructions to detached awns.
- D) The awns' tissue structure can produce movement without an active response from a living seed.

R2-024

What is the main function of the final paragraph?

- A) To claim that outdoor conditions are simpler than chamber conditions.
- B) To qualify how widely the chamber results can be applied while emphasizing what the experiment demonstrates.
- C) To introduce evidence that humidity has no effect on intact awns.
- D) To argue that future studies should examine only smooth clay.

R2-025

Which choice best summarizes the experiment's findings?

- A) Trimmed seeds moved farther than intact seeds on every surface because awns added weight.
- B) Intact seeds always returned to their starting places, regardless of surface.
- C) Twisting awns produced movement, and cracks or leaf edges could anchor that movement, although litter sometimes blocked it.
- D) Only living seeds moved because dead plant tissue could not respond to humidity.

PART B - ANSWER KEY + EXPLANATIONS

R2-001 - Correct: C) It would require major changes to her tidy map and might delay printing.

Explanation: Tessa thinks the alternate route will force her to redraw nearly everything, and she later notes that changing it may cause them to miss the pickup deadline.

R2-002 - Correct: A) give Tessa time to choose an accurate route instead of rushing to print.

Explanation: After Tessa explains the problem, her father says the machine can wait and asks whether the walkers can. His response puts their safety and the map's accuracy before the deadline.

R2-003 - Correct: D) quiet, as if waiting for a decision.

Explanation: The press light has just been switched off, ending the shop's usual clicking and humming. The figurative phrase emphasizes the quiet pause while Tessa considers what to do.

R2-004 - Correct: B) It turns a warning into visible evidence that causes Tessa to reconsider her map.

Explanation: Seeing the water and imagining walkers approaching it makes the danger concrete. Tessa then views the line on her map as a promise she has not checked.

R2-005 - Correct: C) She begins by valuing neatness and shortness but comes to see directions as a responsibility to walkers.

Explanation: At first, Tessa defends the tidy page and shortest route. After seeing the flood, she realizes that the map makes a promise and revises it so walkers can rely on it.

R2-006 - Correct: A) After checking a warned-about route, Tessa accepts a printing delay and redesigns her map to guide walkers safely along a more interesting path.

Explanation: Tessa verifies Mr. Okafor's warning, replaces the unsafe route, and uses features of the longer path to improve the event despite the delayed printing.

R2-007 - Correct: D) Clearly labeled reproductions can help visitors explore features that originals cannot safely demonstrate.

Explanation: Passage A argues that copies can be handled, opened, and tested while the originals remain protected, provided the copies are honestly labeled.

R2-008 - Correct: B) To illustrate how a reproduction can make an original object's operation easier to understand.

Explanation: The working reproduction lets visitors operate the handle and observe the mechanism, while the original stays protected nearby. It provides a concrete example of the author's argument.

R2-009 - Correct: A) They may provide evidence about how that particular object was made and used.

Explanation: Passage B describes knife marks and a darkened thumb patch as physical evidence connected to the making and use of one particular bowl.

R2-010 - Correct: C) substitutes made to represent original objects.

Explanation: The phrase appears in a discussion of reproductions that lack the original's exact wear and history, so "stand-ins" means substitutes representing originals.

R2-011 - Correct: D) what unique physical evidence an original object preserves.

Explanation: Passage A stresses handling and demonstrating copies. Passage B focuses on the marks, wear, repairs, and uncertainties preserved only by a particular original.

R2-012 - Correct: B) A reproduction can be useful when its role is clear and it directs attention to historical evidence.

Explanation: Passage A requires honest labels and treats copies as tools for questioning originals. Passage B accepts models and touchable copies when they guide attention back to surviving evidence.

R2-013 - Correct: C) Writing ideas silently before discussion may broaden the ideas and participation included in a group's conversation.

Explanation: Silent-first teams considered more distinct proposals and shared speaking time more evenly, supporting the idea that a brief writing period can widen the discussion.

R2-014 - Correct: A) Silent-first teams considered more distinct proposals on average than open-discussion teams.

Explanation: The silent-first teams considered an average of 6.7 proposals, compared with 4.1 for the open-discussion teams.

R2-015 - Correct: D) To illustrate how anonymity may shift attention from a speaker's reputation to the idea itself.

Explanation: The comment directly contrasts evaluating an anonymous suggestion with first judging whether its author usually offers good ideas.

R2-016 - Correct: B) To make time equal across conditions so the opening routine was the main planned difference.

Explanation: Both conditions lasted twelve minutes, but only the silent-first condition reserved four minutes for individual writing. Equal total time makes the opening routine the main designed difference.

R2-017 - Correct: C) Speaking time was more evenly distributed, and students said anonymous cards helped ideas from infrequent speakers receive consideration.

Explanation: More even speaking time is direct evidence about participation, while the interviews explain how anonymity helped suggestions from less frequent speakers enter the discussion.

R2-018 - Correct: A) It introduces a concern about group discussions, describes a comparison study, reports results and limitations, and explains a possible application.

Explanation: The passage moves from the first-speaker problem to the two routines, then presents results, interviews, limits, and Perez's description of writing as an entry into discussion.

R2-019 - Correct: D) Humidity-driven twisting of awns can reposition seeds, but the outcome depends on the surface and available anchors.

Explanation: Intact awns moved in response to humidity, while cracks and leaf edges could anchor and guide that movement or sometimes obstruct it.

R2-020 - Correct: B) To distinguish movement caused by awns from movement caused by handling or air currents.

Explanation: The passage states that trimmed seeds served as a comparison for separating awn-driven motion from shifts due to air currents or handling.

R2-021 - Correct: C) advanced in small steps while being held from fully slipping backward.

Explanation: An awn caught on a crack, the seed rotated, and the crack held the new position during the next humidity change. The seed therefore advanced step by step without fully reversing.

R2-022 - Correct: A) The researchers photographed the seeds' starting positions on the three prepared surfaces.

Explanation: The team arranged the seeds and photographed their starting positions before placing the trays in the chamber for twenty dry-humid cycles.

R2-023 - Correct: D) The awns' tissue structure can produce movement without an active response from a living seed.

Explanation: The detached awns came from seeds unable to grow yet still responded to humidity, supporting the passage's physical explanation based on fiber arrangement.

R2-024 - Correct: B) To qualify how widely the chamber results can be applied while emphasizing what the experiment demonstrates.

Explanation: The paragraph contrasts regular chamber cycles with more complex outdoor conditions, limiting generalization, and then states the broader finding about using humidity changes for movement.

R2-025 - Correct: C) Twisting awns produced movement, and cracks or leaf edges could anchor that movement, although litter sometimes blocked it.

Explanation: Intact awns shifted seeds during humidity cycles; cracks and some leaf edges provided anchors, while other leaf arrangements tangled the awns and limited movement.